

INTRODUCTION TO THEOLOGY

Comprehensive BTh Study Notes for the Indian Context

PART THREE: The Historical Development of Theology

Prepared for Bachelor of Theology students. These notes are self-contained. In this part we walk through nearly two thousand years. Do not rush. History is best learned the way a village elder tells a long story: slowly, and with a few laughs along the way.

Before We Begin: Does Theology "Develop"?

A beginner sometimes worries: if theology has a history, does that mean the faith keeps changing? The answer is no. The **faith** does not change, but our **understanding** of it grows, like a seed becoming a tree. The oak is not a betrayal of the acorn. It is the acorn grown up.

The Church calls this the **development of doctrine**. Blessed John Henry Newman taught that a genuine development keeps the same faith while unfolding it more fully, the way a child grows into an adult and yet remains the same person.

Keep this in mind as we travel through five great stages:

1. The **Evangelists and Hagiographers** (the first theologians)
 2. The **Apostolic Period**
 3. The **Patristic Period** (the age of the Fathers)
 4. The **Scholastic Period** (the age of the schools)
 5. The **Modern Period** (the age of renewal and the Second Vatican Council)
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1. The Evangelists and Hagiographers: The First Theologians

Before there were professors and textbooks, there were the **Evangelists** (the Gospel writers) and the **hagiographers** (the sacred writers of Scripture). They were the first theologians.

Here is a point that surprises many students. The **New Testament is not only the source of theology; it is theology itself**. The Gospel writers were not simply reporters jotting down facts. They were interpreters of the mystery of Jesus. They witnessed how the Apostles and the early Church understood who Jesus was, and they set this understanding down in writing. For this reason the New Testament is called **Normative Theology**: it is the standard against which all later theology is measured.

Key Points:

- The Bible does not merely contain theology; the Bible **is** the first and normative theology.
- The Evangelists were interpreters, each with his own way of presenting the one Christ (which is why Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John differ in tone and arrangement while agreeing on the one Lord).
- All later theology, however brilliant, must submit to this first theology of the sacred writers.

Indian Context Example:

In the Indian tradition, the highest authority is the **shruti**, "that which is heard," the primary revealed scripture, above all later commentary. No matter how great a later acharya may be, his **bhashya** (commentary) is always measured against the shruti and never above it. The New Testament stands in the same relation to all later theology. Karl Rahner and Joseph Ratzinger are giants, but they are commentators. The Evangelists are the shruti of the Church.

Illustration:

Imagine the very first witnesses of a great event, who write down what they saw while it is still fresh, guided and inspired. Every later historian must return to those first accounts. If a later writer contradicts the eyewitnesses, we trust the eyewitnesses. The Evangelists are those inspired first witnesses, and their testimony governs the whole later tradition.

Application:

When you preach, you are a commentator on the shruti of the Church. Never let your clever ideas rise above the plain testimony of the Gospel. Your job is to make the first theology shine, not to replace it with your own.

2. The Apostolic Period

The **Apostolic Period** is the age of the Apostles and their direct disciples. Its defining feature is that the message was first spread by **preaching**, through **oral transmission**, before much was written down.

At the heart of this preaching was the **kerygma**, a Greek word meaning "proclamation." The kerygma was the compact core of the first-century Gospel. Stated simply, it announced this: **Jesus is the foretold Messiah and Son of God, who offered himself as a sacrifice on the Cross for the redemption of humanity from the reign of sin. Now in his name salvation is proclaimed to all. Repent and believe in him as the sole Lord and God.**

This was also the **molding time** of Scripture and theology, the period when Scripture slowly began to be distinguished from the wider oral Tradition. The early believers lived in the expectation that the Day of the Lord was near.

2.1 The Creed of the Apostles

Out of this period grew the **Apostles' Creed**, a short, memorised summary of the essentials of the faith. A creed (from the Latin **credo**, "I believe") is a compact confession that a believer can hold in the heart and recite from memory.

Key Points:

- The Gospel first traveled by **word of mouth**, faithfully preached, before it was fully written.
- The **kerygma** was the compressed heart of that preaching: Christ crucified, risen, and proclaimed as Lord.
- The **Creed** condensed the essentials into a formula that could be memorised, recited, and defended.

Indian Context Example:

No culture on earth understands faithful oral transmission better than India. For many centuries the Vedas were preserved **orally**, with astonishing precision, before ever being written. The pandits developed elaborate methods of recitation (such as **jata-patha** and **ghana-patha**) that wove the words together forward and backward, so that not a single syllable would be lost across the generations. This is a perfect window into the Apostolic Period. When your students doubt that the Gospel could be faithfully carried by word of mouth before it was written, point to their own Vedic heritage. India proves that a sacred word can be guarded flawlessly on the lips of a faithful community.

The **Creed**, too, has a beautiful Indian parallel. Indian tradition treasures the **mahavakya**, the "great saying" that compresses a whole teaching into a few words, such as **Tat tvam asi** ("That thou art"). The Creed is, in this sense, the great saying of the Christian, a compressed confession carried in the heart.

Illustration:

Think of how a family recipe for a festival sweet is passed from grandmother to mother to daughter, entirely by demonstration and word, for generations, and still tastes the same. The oral transmission of the Gospel was like that living recipe, guarded by a loving community. The kerygma was the essential recipe; the Creed was the recipe written on a card so it would never be forgotten.

A gentle piece of humour:

Seminarians often groan at having to memorise creeds and formulas. Remind them, with a smile, that the early Church had no printed books, no phones, and no photocopiers, and yet carried the whole Gospel in living memory. Compared to a Vedic pandit reciting thousands of verses backward, memorising one Creed is a very light penance.

Application:

Teach your people the Creed, and teach them why each line is there. A community that can recite its faith with understanding is far harder to lead astray than one that cannot. The Creed is a fence around the flock.

3. The Patristic Period

The **Patristic Period** is the age of the **Fathers of the Church** (from the Latin **pater**, father). It runs from after the age of the Apostles down to **A.D. 636 in the West** (ending with Saint Isidore of Seville) and to about **A.D. 700 in the East** (ending with Saint John of Damascus, also called John Damascene).

The Fathers are so important that the Catholic Church holds their teaching second only to the Bible itself. Saint John Paul II called them the pillars of the Church.

The Fathers are grouped by language into three families:

- **Greek Fathers**
- **Latin Fathers**
- **Syriac Fathers**

During this age the great **catechetical centres** flourished: **Rome, Antioch, Alexandria, and Edessa**. This was the golden age of the **Apologists**, who defended and clarified the faith. They wrestled with the deepest questions: the Trinity, one God in three Persons, and the mysterious relationship of the three Persons to one another, which they named **perichoresis** (Greek for the mutual interpenetration, the "being-in-one-another," of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit). They also worked out the role of the sacraments, Christian morals, and the norms of worship. From this age came the formulation of the Creed at **Nicaea (325)** and **Constantinople (381)**.

3.1 The Most Important Fathers to Know

- **Saint Clement of Rome**, third successor of Saint Peter.
- **Saint Ignatius of Antioch**, bishop of Antioch (about 70 to 107).
- **Saint Justin Martyr**, the greatest of the early apologists.
- **Saint Irenaeus of Lyons**, often called the father of theology.
- **Origen of Alexandria**, a crucial figure in the whole development of Christian thought.
- **Tertullian** of Carthage.
- **Saint John Chrysostom** of Constantinople (349 to 407), the "golden-mouthed" preacher.
- **Saint Jerome**, the great Bible scholar and translator (347 to 419).
- **Saint Ephrem the Syrian** (306 to 373), the great Syriac poet-theologian.
- **Saint Augustine** of Hippo, the Doctor of Grace.

3.2 The Four Great Councils of the Patristic Age

These four councils are the great milestones of Catholic theological progress. Learn each one by its **date**, its **enemy** (the heresy it opposed), and its **result** (the truth it defended).

1. The Council of Nicaea (325)

- **Against:** Arianism, the teaching of Arius that the Son was a created being and not truly God.
- **Result:** it affirmed that the Son is **homoousios** (Greek for "consubstantial," of the same being) with the Father. The Son is truly God.

2. The Council of Constantinople I (381)

- **Against:** the Macedonians, also called the **Pneumatomachi** ("fighters against the Spirit"), who denied the divinity of the Holy Spirit.
- **Result:** it affirmed the divinity of the Holy Spirit and completed the Creed. It was held under the Emperor Theodosius, with Gregory Nazianzus among its leaders. Uniting Christendom was another aim.

3. The Council of Ephesus (431)

- **Against:** Nestorianism, the teaching of Nestorius, Patriarch of Constantinople, that Mary may be called **Christotokos** ("mother of Christ") but not **Theotokos** ("mother of God").
- **Result:** it condemned Nestorius and affirmed that Mary is truly **Theotokos**, the Mother of God, because the one she bore is one divine Person. The champion of orthodoxy here was **Cyril**, Patriarch of Alexandria.

4. The Council of Chalcedon (451)

- **Against:** the heresy of Eutyches and the **Monophysites**, who taught that in Christ the human nature was completely absorbed by the divine, leaving only one nature.
- **Result:** it asserted the orthodox Catholic doctrine that Christ is one Person in **two natures**, truly God and truly man, without confusion and without division.

Key Points:

- The Fathers rank second only to the Bible in Catholic teaching authority.
- The four great councils answered, in order, the deepest questions: Is the Son God (Nicaea)? Is the Spirit God (Constantinople)? Is Mary the Mother of God (Ephesus)? How is Christ both God and man (Chalcedon)?
- Each council was forced upon the Church by a heresy. Error, painful as it is, often made the Church state the truth more clearly.

Indian Context Example:

The word **perichoresis** (the mutual indwelling of the three divine Persons) is worth teaching carefully in India, precisely because it guards against the Trimurti confusion we noted earlier. The Trinity is not three gods standing side by side; it is one God whose three Persons dwell in one another in a communion so complete that they share one single divine

life. The Indian concept of **advaita** (non-duality) can help you here as a bridge, but only if you handle it with care. Advaita speaks of oneness without distinction; the Christian Trinity speaks of oneness **with** real distinction of Persons. Use the comparison to spark thought, then draw the careful line: the Christian God is neither the three separate deities of a crude Trimurti nor the distinctionless absolute of strict advaita, but a communion of three Persons in one being.

For **Theotokos**, India offers a pastoral bridge and a pastoral warning together. Indian devotion to the divine mother (as **Amba, Durga, Mata**) means your people will warm quickly to Mary as Mother. That warmth is good. But you must teach clearly that Mary is **not** a goddess. She is the Mother of God because she bore in her womb the one divine Person of the Son. She is honoured, not worshipped. Worship belongs to God alone.

Illustration:

Think of India defending its Constitution. When a wrong interpretation threatens the nation, the Supreme Court is convened, hears the arguments, and issues a definitive judgment that settles the matter for all. The four councils were the Supreme Court of the early Church, convened when heresy threatened the faith, issuing definitive judgments that settled the matter for all generations.

A famous and much-loved piece of council humour:

There is an old tradition that at the Council of Nicaea, Saint Nicholas of Myra (yes, the very saint who became Santa Claus) grew so angry at the blasphemy of Arius that he walked up and slapped him across the face. Historians debate whether it really happened, but seminarians everywhere love the story, because it means that the original Santa Claus once punched a heretic for denying the divinity of Christ. Tell the story with a laugh, and then make the serious point: the Fathers did not defend the faith with slaps but with Scripture and reason. Still, it shows how fiercely they loved the truth about Christ.

Application:

Every heresy the councils faced is still alive today under new names, especially in India, where fashionable teachers reduce Jesus to "just a good guru" (a modern Arianism) or blur him into an impersonal absolute (a modern kind of confusion). When your people hear such things, the four councils give you your answer, clear and tested by centuries.

4. The Scholastic Period

In its strict sense, **scholasticism** means "that which belongs to the schools." It refers to the way of teaching and presenting theology that arose in the **medieval university classroom**. The Greek **scholastikos** and its Latin form **scholasticus** originally meant a professional theologian.

The great project of scholasticism was to **unite Greek philosophy with Christian dogma**, and above all to reconcile **Aristotle** with Christian theology. In one phrase, scholasticism

was the great attempt to reconcile **faith and reason**, building theology upon Aristotelian philosophical principles.

The renowned scholastic theologians include Saint Anselm of Canterbury, Peter Abelard, Alexander of Hales, Albert the Great, Bonaventure, Thomas Aquinas, Duns Scotus, William of Ockham, and Gabriel Biel.

The period is usually divided into three:

- **Early Scholasticism:** about 1000 to 1250.
- **High Scholasticism:** about 1250 to 1350.
- **Late Scholasticism:** about 1350 to 1500.

4.1 Saint Anselm of Canterbury (1033 to 1109): The Father of Scholasticism

Anselm gave scholasticism its motto. He said: **credo ut intelligam**, "I believe so that I may understand." In his own fuller words: "For I do not seek to understand in order to believe, but I believe in order to understand. For unless I believe, I will not understand."

This is the golden rule of the whole scholastic project. Faith comes first and opens the door; reason then enters and explores the room. This approach is also called **fides quaerens intellectum**, "faith seeking understanding."

4.2 Saint Thomas Aquinas (1225 to 1274): The Aristotle of Christianity

Because he so magnificently synthesised philosophy and theology, Aquinas is called the Aristotle of Christianity. In his famous argument for God as the necessary being, he concluded that there must be "something which is necessary of itself, having no cause of its necessity outside itself, but being the cause of necessity in other things, and this all people call God."

Key Points:

- Scholasticism is the marriage of **faith and reason**, using Aristotle to serve Christian theology.
- **Anselm** set the pattern: believe in order to understand (**credo ut intelligam**).
- **Aquinas** brought the pattern to its summit, showing that faith and reason are friends, not enemies.

Indian Context Example:

The scholastic marriage of faith and reason has a striking parallel in the Indian **darshana** tradition, and especially in the school of **Nyaya**, the great Indian system of logic. The Indian acharyas did not oppose reason to revelation. Like the scholastics, they used rigorous logic (**tarka**) in the **service** of the revealed shruti. Shankara believed first in the authority of the Upanishads and then reasoned magnificently to expound them, which is almost exactly Anselm's **credo ut intelligam**. When you teach Indian students that faith and reason are friends, tell them their own Vedantic tradition already knew this. The Christian scholastics

and the Vedantic acharyas were, in this one respect, doing the same kind of work: reasoning from within faith.

Illustration:

Consider a lamp and eyes. Faith is the lamp that gives light; reason is the eyes that see by that light. Eyes without a lamp see nothing in the dark, and a lamp without eyes shines on no one. Anselm and Aquinas taught that we need both: the lamp of faith and the eyes of reason, working together.

A tender piece of humour about Aquinas:

Thomas Aquinas wrote more than almost any theologian in history, tens of thousands of pages of the tightest reasoning. Yet near the end of his life he had a profound mystical experience while celebrating Mass, after which he simply stopped writing. When his secretary begged him to continue, Aquinas replied, "I cannot, because all that I have written seems to me like straw compared with what I have seen." The greatest reasoner in the history of the Church ended by confessing that his mountain of learning was straw before the living God. This is not a joke exactly, but it will make your students smile and grow quiet at the same time. It is the whole lesson of theology on the knees in one sentence.

4.3 The Decline of Scholasticism and the Reformation

Scholasticism declined for several reasons. The Reformation held that reason cannot help us know God. Moreover, scholasticism had failed to give **Scripture and Tradition** the central place they truly deserved. Its over-emphasis on reason, and its effort to philosophise the truths of faith, were serious weaknesses.

The Reformation movements can be positively evaluated as an effort to free theology from an over-philosophised scholasticism. **Martin Luther** tried to bring Christian theology back to its biblical sources, longing for a Scripture-based theology under the banner **sola scriptura** ("Scripture alone").

But the creative proposals of that age were not accepted in their extreme form, and the Church again followed the scholastic pattern to explain the faith. The tragedy, the source notes soberly, is that Catholic theologians of the time often could not read the signs of the times, and failed to develop a theology with "the smell of life."

4.4 The Council of Trent (1545 to 1563)

The Council of Trent was convened against the Protestant revolution. It condemned what it defined as the errors of Protestantism, and issued key clarifications of Catholic doctrine on Scripture, the biblical canon, sacred Tradition, original sin, justification, salvation, the sacraments, the Mass, and the veneration of the saints.

Application:

The scholastic period teaches a permanent lesson. Reason is a gift, but a theology that becomes only clever argument, cut off from Scripture and from the living needs of real people, loses "the smell of life." In your ministry, keep your theology reasonable but never

let it become a cold machine. Luther, for all his errors, was reacting against a faith that had grown dry. Keep yours moist with Scripture and warm with charity.

5. Theology in the Modern Period

The twentieth century is often called **the century of the Church**. In this age, theology freed itself from its old scholastic stiffness. The riches of **Scripture, Liturgy, and Tradition** were rediscovered. A new understanding of the Church developed, above all the beautiful image of the **Church as the People of God**. Scripture regained its central place in the whole theological process, and the rise of **contextual theologies** became a special mark of the age.

5.1 The Challenges: The Modern "Isms"

Modern theology has had to face fierce attacks from many philosophical trends and "isms": **Rationalism, Idealism, Empiricism, Existentialism, Marxism, Humanism, Pragmatism, Liberalism, Personalism, and Feminism**, among others. The risk for a twentieth-century theologian is to engage all these movements honestly while keeping the Catholic faith alive and whole amid their pressure.

5.2 The Second Vatican Council (1962 to 1965)

The Second Vatican Council was an epoch-making event, the twenty-first ecumenical council of the Roman Catholic Church. It was announced by **Pope John XXIII** as a means of spiritual renewal for the Church and as an occasion to seek Christian unity. In the words of Pope John XXIII, it sought **aggiornamento**, an Italian word meaning "a bringing up to date," so that the Church might speak to the modern world.

5.3 The Return of the Bible

In the Catholic theological world, biblical studies gained new predominance, encouraged by a series of important documents: **Divino Afflante Spiritu** (1943), **Dei Verbum** (1965), and later **Verbum Domini** (2010). The Bible returned to the very heart of Catholic theology.

5.4 Ten Modern Theologians You Should Know

- **Henri de Lubac**, author of *Medieval Exegesis*.
- **Yves Congar**, author of *Tradition and Traditions*.
- **Karl Rahner**, the great dogmatic theologian.
- **Jean Daniélou**, author of *God and the Ways of Knowing*.
- **Dietrich Bonhoeffer**, author of *Ethics* (a Lutheran martyr under the Nazis, honoured across the Churches).
- **Edward Schillebeeckx**, the Dominican theologian.
- **Walter Kasper**, dogmatic theologian and cardinal.
- **Joseph Ratzinger**, later Pope Benedict XVI.
- **Hans Urs von Balthasar**, the theologian of beauty.

- **Avery Dulles**, author of works on the theology of revelation.

Key Points:

- The twentieth century recovered Scripture, Liturgy, and Tradition, and pictured the Church afresh as the **People of God**.
- Modern theology must engage the many "isms" without being swallowed by them.
- The **Second Vatican Council** sought **aggiornamento**, an updating of the Church for the modern world.
- The Bible returned to the centre, and a rich generation of theologians renewed the field.

Indian Context Example:

The modern period is exactly where the **Indian Church came into its own theological voice**. As the twentieth century recovered contextual theology, India produced pioneers who tried to express Christ in genuinely Indian categories. **Brahmabandhab Upadhyay** attempted to speak of God as **Saccidananda** (being, consciousness, bliss), reading the Trinity through Vedantic language. After the Second Vatican Council, the Indian Church embraced **aggiornamento** in a distinctly Indian way: the effort at inculturated liturgy, the work of centres such as the National Biblical, Catechetical and Liturgical Centre in Bangalore, and the flowering of Indian Christian theology (including the Dalit, Adivasi, and feminist theologies we met in Part Two). When you teach the modern period, do not leave it in Europe. Bring it home: the aggiornamento of Vatican II is the reason the Indian Church could begin to sing the Gospel in an Indian voice.

Illustration:

Pope John XXIII famously said that in calling the Council he wanted to "open the windows of the Church and let in some fresh air." Picture an old house, beautiful but shut up for years, its windows sealed, the air stale. The master throws open the windows, and fresh air and sunlight pour in, without knocking down a single load-bearing wall. That is aggiornamento: fresh air, not demolition. The house is the same house, now able to breathe.

A delightful piece of humour from Pope John XXIII:

Pope John XXIII was famous for his warmth and wit. When a visitor once asked him, "How many people work in the Vatican?", the Pope reportedly answered with a twinkle, "About half of them." Tell this to your students, and then make the point gently: even the Pope who opened the windows of the Church could laugh at himself and his own institution. A theologian who can laugh at himself is far less likely to become a fanatic. Aggiornamento began with a Pope who had a sense of humour.

Application:

You are a theologian of this modern period, and in India you serve at one of its most creative frontiers. Your calling is Pope John XXIII's calling: to keep the ancient faith whole while opening the windows so that the fresh air of the Gospel can reach the actual people of West

Bengal and of India. Engage the modern "isms" with honesty, learn from the great theologians, but always bring the Gospel home to your own soil.

PART THREE SUMMARY: Main Takeaways

1. Theology **develops** without changing: the oak is not a betrayal of the acorn. The **faith** stays the same while our **understanding** grows.
2. The **Evangelists and hagiographers** were the first theologians. The New Testament is **Normative Theology**, the shruti of the Church, above all later commentary.
3. The **Apostolic Period** spread the Gospel by faithful **oral transmission** (like the Vedic pandits), centred on the **kerygma** and condensed in the **Creed**.
4. The **Patristic Period** is the age of the Fathers, ranked second only to the Bible. Its **four great councils** answered the deepest questions in order: the divinity of the Son (**Nicaea, 325**), the divinity of the Spirit (**Constantinople I, 381**), Mary as Mother of God (**Ephesus, 431**), and the two natures of Christ (**Chalcedon, 451**).
5. The **Scholastic Period** married **faith and reason** using Aristotle. **Anselm** gave the motto **credo ut intelligam**; **Aquinas** brought it to its summit, and ended by calling all his writing "straw" before the living God. Its decline provoked the **Reformation** (Luther, **sola scriptura**) and the response of the **Council of Trent (1545 to 1563)**.
6. The **Modern Period**, "the century of the Church," recovered Scripture, Liturgy, and the image of the **People of God**. The **Second Vatican Council (1962 to 1965)** sought **aggiornamento**, opening the windows of the Church, and in India it gave birth to a genuinely Indian theological voice.

A word to carry forward: From the first witnesses to the open windows of Vatican II, the Holy Spirit has guided the Church to understand her one faith ever more deeply. You now stand in that long line. Remember Aquinas calling his life's work "straw," remember Pope John XXIII opening the windows with a laugh, and take your own place in the story with both humility and joy.

End of Part Three. Part Four will turn to the General Introduction to the Bible: the meaning of the word "Bible," the Catholic and Protestant canons, the deuterocanonical books, the formation of the canon at the great councils, the Council of Jamnia, and the major translations of Scripture, with the same Indian contextualisation and humour.